



MONTHLY UPDATE

Malawi: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-06 · 33 systems and instruments tracked, 57 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-06 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Two things moved in Malawi between 1 July and 6 August 2026, in opposite directions. The data protection regime crossed from paper into scope: the twenty-four-month exemption in the Data Protection Act 2024 elapsed in early June, and on 13 July the regulator consulted on draft regulations, guidelines and a registration fee schedule ([consultation account](#)). At the same time the regulator enforced consumer telecommunications law against both mobile operators, ordering compensation for a tariff-notice breach ([regulator order](#)).

The month also produced the clearest statement yet of what local-government digitisation has not achieved: councils receiving clean audit opinions fell to 18 in 2024/25 from 22, announced on the same day as a public real-time spending dashboard ([launch account](#)).

Infrastructure

The communications regulator found both mobile operators in breach of the tariff-notice requirement on 17 July 2026, for failing to publish approved tariff changes in at least two daily newspapers seven days before they took effect. Both agreed to credit customers who bought affected products between 26 June and 2 July with bundles equal to the price difference, and to submit evidence of compliance by 31 July ([regulator order](#)). The approved price increase itself stands.

The ICT minister told Parliament on 17 July that additional mobile operator licences are under consideration, and on 24 July that the President had authorised the ministry to identify an investor able to roll out a network without delay; no bid timetable, licence terms or spectrum allocation was stated. The minister also told the House that spectrum licence fees had been reduced by 50%, against the 20% the regulator announced in June 2025, and cited an 8% rise in electricity tariffs and a roughly 144% rise in fuel prices in the operators' cost case ([parliamentary account](#)).

Digital public infrastructure

The registration bureau reported on 13 July 2026 that more than 13.5 million people hold a national digital identity, with over 150,000 enrolled between April and June, 53% of them women ([registration bureau](#)). On 6 July it named the forthcoming mobile credential and set its launch for September 2026 ([registration bureau](#)). On 5 August a separate blockchain-enabled wallet built by the United Nations Development Programme was stated to be in pilot ahead of nationwide rollout; neither announcement names the other.

Passport printing resumed at Mangochi, stated in Parliament on 20 July, where a member said applicants who filed nine months to a year earlier were being overtaken by same-day issuances. The homeland security minister accepted in principle a sequence number assigned at application.

The Electronic Invoicing System reached 8,552 registered taxpayers by 20 July, and about 8,000 landlords were registered for rental income tax. On 3 July the e-government department agreed integration of immigration e-services onto the national exchange platform ([e-government department](#)). On 5 August the revenue authority signed an arrangement with its South African counterpart for real-time customs data exchange, with no go-live date and no published purpose-limitation, retention or reciprocity terms ([signing account](#)).

Governance and regulation

The communications regulator consulted stakeholders at Blantyre on 13 July 2026 on draft Data Protection Regulations and a registration fee schedule setting annual fees by turnover from MWK 50,000 for small and medium enterprises to MWK 7 million for the largest controllers and processors of significant importance ([consultation account](#)). The consultation follows the elapse in early June of the twenty-four-month exemption that had kept most controllers outside the Act's obligations since commencement ([the Act](#)). No commencement date for the regulations was announced.

A consultative meeting concluded in Lilongwe reviewing the National Registration Act and the marriage and family relations statute, with the registration bureau stating the aim is to support a modern and secure civil registration and identification system; no bill, draft or timetable was placed on record.

The statutory copyright society's position on artificial intelligence became public on 23 July: it will not register works created entirely by artificial intelligence or distribute royalties on them. Its own statement is not held, the decision date is not established, and no test was published for how much assistance is admissible. On 3 August the same body's blank media levy distribution was reported to rest on records submitted by licensed disc-burning centres rather than on digital consumption, with a proposal to key distribution to digital consumption voted down at an annual general meeting.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

A UNESCO artificial intelligence readiness assessment was validated in Lilongwe on 22 July 2026, run by the education ministry rather than by the ICT ministry that owns the draft national strategy. It reported gaps in policy, infrastructure, institutional capacity and education readiness, and put 27.7% of the population online with household computer ownership at 4.2% ([validation account](#)). The strategy it is intended to guide remains pre-adoption.

Applied deployments in the month were single facilities rather than national systems: a university commissioned an artificial-intelligence fertigation system at its Thyolo campus on 17 July, automating irrigation and fertiliser application from real-time crop data, with no cost or funding source stated.

On 24 July the Defence Minister stated that the Malawi Defence Force intends to adopt artificial intelligence in military operations and to learn it from the Chinese army, within a relationship he described as extending past exchanges into specialised training, equipment supply and institutional development. No Malawian doctrine, oversight body, budget line or civilian-control provision for military artificial intelligence is on file, and the draft national strategy as reported does not cover it.

Inclusion, capacity and finance

Parliament ratified an SDR 58.2m grant for the successor local-government service delivery project on 29 July 2026, covering 32 councils with four entering for the first time, of which US\$12.8m funds business-process re-engineering, system assessments and a performance dashboard ([parliamentary approval](#)). The predecessor closed on 30 June.

The results announced on 31 July give the counterpoint. Councils receiving clean audit opinions fell to 18 in 2024/25 from 22 the year before, with one district council receiving an adverse opinion — disclosed at the same event that launched a public real-time dashboard for tracking constituency development spending ([launch account](#)). No address for that dashboard is established in anything the wiki holds, so it cannot be inspected.

On 25 July the central bank's expected banknote replacement cost for 2026 was reported at MWK 69.8bn against MWK 50.6bn in 2025, with an economists' association president naming government levies on digital money transfers as a reason cash use persists.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	2026-08-06
CURRENT EDITION	https://corpus.data-landscapers.com/reports/MWI/MWI-monthly-2026-07.html
THIS FILE	https://corpus.data-landscapers.com/reports/MWI/MWI-monthly-2026-07-2026-08-06.pdf
DERIVED FROM	Data Landscapers source base, commit <code>ea6e045ec0be</code>
VERIFY	Hash this file and look it up in https://corpus.data-landscapers.com/manifest.csv
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